

CRUCIBLE

Work Instructions

Write. Organize. Revise. Save.

Version 1.9.3 | Updated 1 November 2026

A practical guide to the portable browser edition, with desktop differences identified where relevant.

AI is optional. You can write, organize and export without configuring an AI provider.

This edition replaces the 1.8 instructions and covers the 1.9.3 refinement build. Your books and settings remain separate from the program file.

The author statement in About remains unchanged. Open File > About Crucible to read it.

Start here

Crucible stores the manuscript as Markdown and keeps notes, story memory, editing history and other book data beside it. The ready-to-open browser program is crucible.html. The source directory is editable program code, not a prebuilt Windows executable.

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What changed in 1.9.3

Saves protect edits made while a write is running. Save failures stay visible with a Retry save button. Book switching offers Save and continue, Discard changes, or Cancel. AI work blocks book switching while active. The AI desk explains its context, and folder selection in Settings checks imported AI addresses.

Based on the reviewed 1.9.3 build. Focused browser and regression checks passed; full desktop, export, restore and live paid-AI testing remain incomplete.

Open Crucible

Browser edition: computer or USB drive

1. Extract the refinement ZIP into a separate folder. Find the crucible.html at the package root and open it in Chrome or Edge.

2. Choose the Crucible-folder option and select your working folder. Grant file-editing permission when prompted. You can make a new folder using the folder picker or your file manager.

3. Keep books in this folder or named subfolders. On later visits, reconnect the remembered folder with Open <folder> and grant permission again if requested.

4. Create and save a practice book. Close and reopen it to confirm that the saved file and its companion data are available.

If folder editing is unavailable, Crucible can fall back to browser storage. That storage is tied to that browser, not to a portable USB folder. Download a manuscript copy before clearing browser data or changing computers.

Desktop edition

If you have a separately supplied portable Windows build, extract its complete package and run Crucible.exe. Keep its supporting files together. The 1.9.3 refinement ZIP contains the browser HTML and source, not a newly built Windows executable.

Make the workspace comfortable

Use the Light/Dark button to switch appearance. Write shows editable Markdown; Split shows editing and preview; Read shows the rendered manuscript. Collapse side panels or use Focus when you need more writing space.

Offline use

Writing and local file work do not need a hosted AI. Cloud AI requests need a connection and a provider account. A local model service must be running and configured to accept Crucible requests. Any provider usage charges are separate from Crucible.

Create, open and save books

1. Choose File > New book. Replace the starter title and chapter heading.

2. Use Ctrl+Shift+S for Save as. Choose a book folder and filename, such as The Lantern House.md.

3. Use Open or Ctrl+O to reopen an existing .md manuscript. Crucible loads companion data from the adjacent matching .crucible folder.

4. Use Ctrl+S after meaningful changes. Autosave is optional, runs at five-minute intervals when enabled, and requires an already named book.

Keep together	Purpose
The Lantern House.md	Editable manuscript.
The Lantern House.crucible/	Notes, pool, chat, memory, metadata and manuscript backups.
Images and linked media	Files referenced by the manuscript or research links.
crucible-settings.json	Browser folder settings; may contain API keys.

Move a complete project

One named folder per book makes projects easier to manage. Copy the manuscript, matching companion folder and referenced assets together. External links may point elsewhere; include or relink those files, or use Package & back up.

Bring in an existing manuscript

Open a Markdown book directly. For other manuscript formats, obtain a Markdown or plain-text version first and check its paragraphs, headings and pictures. This build does not provide a verified PDF-reading/import or Word-manuscript import workflow.

A PDF, Word or EPUB export is a delivery copy. Keep the editable .md book and companion folder for continued work. Opening a research .md file as a book is different from importing it into Story memory.

Save status and recovery

Status	What to do
Not saved yet	Use Save or Save as to name and store the book.
Unsaved changes	Writing or book data needs saving.
Saving	A snapshot is being written. Wait before closing or removing a drive.
Saved / Autosaved + time	That save completed. Check that no newer changes remain unsaved.
No unsaved changes	The opened book currently has no changes marked for saving; this is not a new save confirmation.
Save failed - retry	Read the error, restore folder access, then use Retry save or Save as.

You can continue typing during a save

A save writes a snapshot of the manuscript and book data. Edits made afterward remain marked unsaved when that save finishes. Save again to write them. Repeated Save clicks during an active write share that operation; they do not queue a separate save of newer text.

Before leaving a changed book

New, Open and recent-book navigation use the same decision: Save and continue saves first; Discard changes leaves without preserving the unsaved changes; Cancel keeps the current book open. A failed or canceled save does not authorize the switch. If you edited during the save, save the newer changes before continuing.

Wait for an AI-desk reply to finish, or stop the Prose pass and let its active request finish, before switching books. This keeps results associated with the intended manuscript. New chat is also blocked while an AI-desk reply is in progress.

Recover from a failed save

1. Keep the app open. Reconnect or unlock the drive and restore write permission.

2. Click Retry save. If the location is still unavailable, use File > Save as to save in another accessible location.

3. Confirm the saved filename and status before closing. Pause typing for the final save, close the app, then safely remove the USB drive.

Write and organize chapters

Markdown in Write view	Rendered result
# The Lantern House	Book title.
## Chapter One: The Letter	Chapter heading and outline entry.
### The Harbor	Smaller scene heading.
bold / *italic*	Emphasis.
*** on its own line	Scene break.
Blank line between paragraphs	Separate paragraphs.

Everyday editing

Write or Split is for entering text; Read or preview shows formatting. Ctrl+F or Ctrl+H opens finding and replacing. In the browser edition, Shift+right-click exposes the browser spelling menu. Right-click > Align changes paragraph alignment; alignment markers can remain visible in Markdown.

Chapter builder

1. Open Chapter builder from the Outline area or File menu.

2. Select a chapter. Rename it, add another, change order with the controls, or choose numbering options.

3. When deleting, distinguish removing only a heading from removing the whole chapter and its text.

4. Add a chapter image if wanted, review the order, and choose Apply changes.

5. Check the Outline and manuscript, then save. Back up before major restructuring.

Bulk operations can reset earlier typing undo history. Undo can reverse the applied bulk change, but a separate backup is the better recovery point for an extended restructuring session.

Space to write

Ctrl+[toggles the left panel; Ctrl+] toggles the right; Ctrl+backslash toggles Focus. Restore panels when you need Outline, Notes, the pool or AI tools. Click Today in the status area for writing goals; word-count progress is net additions, so cutting text can reduce it.

Notes and the change pool

Type	Use it for
Margin note	An editorial reminder anchored to text.
Change pool note	An instruction about a passage you want AI to revise.
Story memory note	Persistent facts and rules beyond the manuscript.

Add and manage a margin note

1. Select text or place the cursor in its paragraph. Press Alt+N or use the right-click margin-note command.

2. Enter the reminder. In Notes, use Edit to revise it, Show to return to the passage, Resolve when finished, or delete a mistaken note.

3. When the cursor is in annotated text, the status area can show a note indicator such as 1 note here. Click it to open the associated note.

Margin notes are not automatically included in AI requests. Put an AI editing instruction in a pool note or the AI message. Put durable background in enabled Story memory. Do not assume a sentence-start icon is the indicator used by this build; the Notes list and cursor-sensitive status indicator are the documented controls.

Queue an AI request

1. Highlight a sentence or passage. Right-click > Add to pool with a note.

2. State both the change and the constraints: Make the coffee stale; preserve the quiet tone and the action.

3. Use Negotiate on that item, or select several items and use the batch Negotiate control. Confirm they appear On the table at the AI desk.

Clean up work

Dismiss removes an item from active work without deleting it; Reopen returns it to pending work. Delete from pool removes a mistaken list item. History records associated edits. Deleting or dismissing an item does not undo text already applied. Review outstanding work using Notes and pool statuses, and save changes to the book data.

AI connections and saved keys

1. Open Settings > + Add an AI and choose a provider preset or compatible service.

2. Enter your API key and the exact model ID from your provider. Chat-service subscriptions and API access can be separate.

3. Use Test to save and send a small request. Resolve the reported error before a longer editing job.

4. Add other connections as needed. Switch using the top AI selector. Edit the model field in Settings to change a connection's model.

Check imported addresses

When folder settings, imported settings or a backup would add or change an AI address, review Check these AI addresses. Choose Use these addresses only for servers you recognize. Keep my current AIs retains your existing connections while other settings can import. Importing does not automatically switch the active AI. Settings folder selection uses this check too.

Changing a provider Base URL or connection type clears its saved key; enter the key intended for that destination. Requests do not follow redirects. If a redirect error appears, verify the correct Base URL instead of repeatedly resending the key.

Keep keys between updates

Browser folder mode normally stores keys in crucible-settings.json. Preserve this file when replacing crucible.html. It is not encrypted. Untick Keep API keys in crucible-settings.json to keep keys off that drive; they may still be retained in the browser. Settings export/import offers a separate choice about including keys.

The desktop edition uses operating-system secure storage when available. Without secure storage, it keeps keys only for the session and asks again after restart. Do not assume desktop key storage transfers between computers like a browser settings file.

Using AI is optional

Writing, organizing and exporting work without an API key. If you press Send with no AI configured, the draft message is retained and Settings opens. Before sharing settings or a backup, check whether keys are included. Never place keys in your manuscript, memory notes or AI messages.

Context and passage rewrites

What the AI receives

Expand What does the AI receive? beside the composer. The AI desk includes up to 30 recent chat messages, including the current message; passages On the table with pool notes and nearby text; and either the whole manuscript when selected, or the outline and opening 1,500 characters. Enabled story memory and selected memory images are supplied when Use story memory is checked, subject to limits. Margin notes are not automatic context. Prose pass and Beta reader use their own selected scope.

To use several models, ask one for analysis, wait for its reply, switch connections, and ask another to revise using the same relevant context. Replies retain the provider selected when their request began. This is shared book context, not autonomous model-to-model conversation. Put accepted decisions into Story memory.

Example: fresh coffee becomes stale coffee

1. Select: The kitchen smelled of fresh coffee.

2. Right-click > Add to pool with a note. Enter: Make the coffee stale instead of fresh. Keep one sentence and preserve the quiet tone.

3. Choose Negotiate. Confirm that sentence appears On the table and select your AI.

4. Send: Rewrite this passage using its note. Return a suggested change I can apply. Ctrl+Enter sends from the AI box.

5. Review the proposed card and its Diff. Ask for adjustments if needed. An acceptable result might be: The kitchen smelled of stale coffee.

6. Choose Apply on the accepted rewrite. Confirm the actual manuscript changed, then save. If you typed during the save, save again after it completes.

A suggestion is not yet an edit

Copy only copies a suggestion. Ordinary chat text does not replace manuscript text. Ask for an apply-ready replacement if no card appears. If the original passage cannot be matched, reselect the current wording and request a fresh replacement. Use Ctrl+Z promptly for a wrong applied edit; deleting its pool item does not reverse it.

Batch revision and continuity

Run a Prose pass

1. Save and make a backup before broad edits. Open Prose pass in the right panel.

2. Choose Selection, Chapter at cursor or Whole book. Choose Proofread, Copy edit or Line edit according to how much change you want.

3. Enter constraints, such as Keep all dialogue unchanged. Enable story memory when the pass should follow established facts.

4. Start the pass. Large sections are processed in chunks. Stop pauses after the current request; Resume continues saved progress. Provider errors can pause a job.

5. Review cards. Show locates a passage, Accept applies a proposal, and Skip leaves the text unchanged. Inspect scope before using Accept all.

6. Use the Accepted filter and Revert for accepted changes you want to reverse. Check the resulting manuscript and save.

A proposal is not applied when its original text cannot be matched. Editing the same passage during a pass can make proposals stale. Reselect or rerun that portion instead of forcing an uncertain replacement. Book switching is blocked while the pass is running.

Check continuity

1. Update and enable the Story memory facts that must remain true.

2. In Prose pass, choose Continuity check and normally Whole book, then Check continuity.

3. Review each contradiction against the story and notes. Use Apply fix when appropriate, or mark I've fixed it / Not a problem.

Continuity checking uses a running fact sheet and enabled memory. It can miss issues or mistake intentional mysteries for errors. Pool batches are for discussing selected passages together; Prose pass provides the structured accept/skip workflow. Beta readers offer simulated reader reactions to the chosen passage or chapter; their feedback remains a suggestion.

Story memory and data imports

A reference shelf beyond the manuscript

1. Open Story memory > + New note. Use focused topics such as Mara - character, Time travel rules, or Harbor geography.

2. Write concise facts and constraints, add useful tags, and enable AI reads this when the note should influence AI work.

3. Enable the AI tool's story-memory option and ask a specific question: Does this scene violate the return-marker rule?

Separate established facts from possibilities and unanswered questions. For example: Travel requires a return marker. A traveler cannot arrive before the marker exists. Losing it prevents return. Record approved decisions here after AI discussions instead of relying only on old chat messages.

Import a Markdown data dump

1. Choose + Photos/files in Story memory and select your .md or .txt background file.

2. Inspect the imported material, give it a useful name, and enable it for AI reading where appropriate.

3. Break long dumps into focused notes and disable irrelevant material for a narrowly scoped request.

Memory is not automatically inserted into the story or printed in exports. Open a manuscript .md as a book; import a background .md into memory. Those operations have different purposes.

Import structured facts

Use + Import data for CSV, TSV or JSON. Inspect the preview, choose the record-identifying field, and decide whether to create a combined note or separate notes per record. Check names and content before relying on the imported information.

Check the context meter

The default story-memory limit is 120,000 characters. Changing it does not expand a model's own context capacity. Later material can be omitted when the limit is exceeded. Inspect truncation warnings, shorten notes or reduce enabled context before asking questions that depend on exact facts.

Scenes, timelines and media

Arrange the story

1. Use chapter headings and scene headings or breaks to divide the manuscript. Open Corkboard from Outline or File.

2. Double-click a scene card to edit its summary, date/time, track and color. Drag cards to change scene order or move between chapters; review and Apply changes.

3. Open Timeline. Use consistent dates, such as 2032-05-04 08:00, and meaningful tracks such as Present, Earlier, or a character thread. Compare story-time order with reading order, then save.

Scene metadata is stored in hidden Markdown comments. Preserve those comments when editing elsewhere. A flashback can appear later in reading order while keeping an earlier story date. Timeline is based on scene metadata; it is not a combined photo-and-facts table with arbitrary custom tabs. Use focused Story memory notes for background topics.

Asset purpose	Where to put it
Picture printed in the book	Chapter image or manuscript image.
AI reference photo	Story memory with a useful description.
Picture tied to a passage	Right-click picture-link command; manage in Links.
Atmosphere or music	Playlist or passage-linked song.

Reference photos and linked pictures

In Story memory, use + Photos/files. Describe the important details and enable AI reads this. To send image pixels, enable Show image to AI and select a model that accepts images. A description alone does not send the picture itself.

To link a picture, select a passage or place the cursor in its paragraph and use the right-click picture-link command. Links offers View, Go to, and Change file. Linked files are not automatically copied into the book or printed as illustrations. Preserve their location or relink after moving.

Listening

Use the right-click read-aloud command for a selection or from the cursor. Choose voice/speed and pause or stop as needed; typing stops narration. Voice availability depends on the system. The separate MP3 player is for listening while you write; see page 16 for playlist and playback instructions.

Export PDF, Word and EPUB

PDF reading copy

1. Save the book. Open Export or press Ctrl+Shift+E and choose PDF.

2. Set page size, margins, font and text size. Choose title-page, page-number and contents options.

3. Set New page for to the heading level used by chapters, normally ## when # is the book title. Enable Book-style indents if wanted, and Leave out comments to omit internal Markdown comments.

4. In the browser, finish through its print window and choose Save as PDF. In the desktop edition, choose the PDF destination.

5. Open the exported PDF and inspect title page, chapter starts, images, contents numbers and first/last lines on pages.

Turn off browser headers/footers if dates, URLs or duplicate headers appear. Check print size and margins against the intended layout. PDF output is supported; a verified PDF import/reading workflow inside this version is not documented. Continue editing the .md book.

Place the contents

Export offers Chapters, Chapters and scenes, or no contents. Contents normally follow front matter before the first chapter. To choose a location, put the cursor there and use right-click > Insert table of contents here. Keep [TOC] on its own line; delete it to return to automatic placement.

Word

Choose Word (.docx), then Manuscript format or Book style. Fill in title and requested author/contact fields. Open the exported file in Word and update the contents field when prompted. After later edits, update that field again. Follow your recipient's formatting requirements rather than assuming the defaults fit every submission.

EPUB

Choose EPUB e-book and fill in available title, author and cover options. Open the result in the intended reader. Test navigation, chapter starts, images and several text sizes. EPUB reflows; its page counts need not match the PDF.

Inspect exports for unwanted internal material. Keep an editable project backup and regenerate delivery files after manuscript revisions. Exports do not replace notes, pool history, memory or settings.

Back up, restore and update

Package a complete workspace

1. Save, then choose Package & back up from the top bar or File. If newer edits remain unsaved after its preliminary save, packaging stops; save again and retry.

2. Review the included books, media, settings and app where offered. Leave API keys out of shared packages unless you deliberately intend to include them.

3. Save the ZIP somewhere separate, preferably another drive. Keep dated copies before major edits and software updates.

Browser packaging uses its selected folder and supported book context; desktop packaging uses known/recent books. Check that needed books and external media are present. Do not assume every manuscript on the computer is included.

Restore and verify

1. Choose the File menu's restore-backup command and select the ZIP.

2. Choose a destination; the restore workflow makes a new restored folder.

3. Open a restored .md file. Check manuscript, memory, notes, pool and linked pictures. Review any imported AI-address prompt before accepting connections.

4. Keep the original backup until the restored project is confirmed usable.

File > Backups previews and restores earlier manuscript versions. The automatic history keeps up to 30 previous .md versions, not complete historical snapshots of all companion data. Inspect the restored text and save when you intend to keep it.

Update without losing keys or books

1. Save and close Crucible. Back up the working folder.

2. Extract the new package separately. Replace only your working folder's crucible.html with the updated browser file.

3. Preserve crucible-settings.json, manuscripts, matching .crucible folders, images and other media.

4. Open the new HTML, reconnect the working folder, and verify a practice copy of a book and its settings.

The 1.9.3 refinement retains the author's About statement verbatim. Updating the program does not require deleting your settings. Copying only the HTML is not a backup of your writing.

Troubleshooting and shortcuts

Symptom	Next step
Save failed / USB unavailable	Keep the app open. Restore access and Retry save, or use Save as elsewhere.
Unsaved after a save	New edits arrived during the write. Save again after it finishes.
Book will not switch	Finish the AI reply or stop Prose pass; resolve the Save / Discard / Cancel choice.
HTTP 404	Check preset, Base URL and exact model ID; this alone does not prove a bad key.
401 / 403 / 429	Check key and model permissions; for 429, check usage limits/credit and retry later.
Timeout or context error	Reduce selection, full-book context or enabled memory.
AI ignored a note	Use pool instructions or enabled memory; margin notes are not sent automatically.
Rewrite did not change text	Use Apply on a card, not Copy. Reselect if the original text no longer matches.
Old text after reopening	Check the saved path, status and duplicate files. Do not discard the open work.
Missing picture / clipped PDF	Repair image paths; inspect print layout, margins and font size before re-exporting.

Shortcut	Action
Ctrl+O / Ctrl+S / Ctrl+Shift+S	Open / Save / Save as.
Alt+A (browser)	Add selection to pool; desktop uses Ctrl+Shift+A.
Alt+N / Ctrl+F or Ctrl+H	Margin note / Find and replace.
Ctrl+Enter / Ctrl+Shift+E	Send from AI box / Export.
Ctrl+[/ Ctrl+] / Ctrl+backslash	Toggle left / right / Focus.
Ctrl+Z / Ctrl+Y / Space	Undo / redo / music toggle outside text entry.

Daily routine: open the correct book; review notes and facts; write; inspect and apply desired revisions; save and confirm status; back up after major work. For a fault report, record version, edition, exact error and reproducible steps. Remove keys from anything you share.

MP3 player: listen while you write

The bottom player is simply for listening to music or other audio while you write: soundtracks, ambient sounds, audiobooks or recordings. It needs no AI and does not add audio to your manuscript or exports.

Add audio and start listening

1. Click Playlist at the bottom right to open the playlist panel.

2. Choose + Songs to select individual audio files, or + Folder to add audio from a folder. The labels say songs, but the content can be speech or any other audio.

3. Click a track name or double-click its row to start. Play starts the first item if none is loaded.

4. Return to writing. Use the bottom controls without leaving your book. Click Playlist again to hide the list.

Control	Operation
Play / Pause	Start or pause the loaded track. Space does the same when you are not typing in an input field.
Previous / Next	Next advances to another track. Previous restarts the current track after more than 3 seconds; near its beginning, it selects the previous track.
Progress slider	Drag to move backward or forward within the loaded track. The times show position and duration.
Volume slider	Adjust listening volume; this preference is saved.
Shuffle	Turn on random selection for the next track. A random choice can select the same track again.
Repeat	Repeat the current track when it ends. With Repeat off, playback advances through the playlist and wraps to the start.

Arrange or remove playlist entries

Use the up/down arrows beside an entry to change its order. Remove deletes that entry from the playlist; Clear asks before removing the whole list. Neither deletes audio files from disk. Pause first if you also want playback to stop; removing or clearing entries is not a stop command.

Keep audio available between sessions

The playlist is shared across books and saved in settings. Files play from their original locations. For USB use, keep audio inside the working folder and use + Folder. Reconnect access if prompted. Browser-storage fallback may retain audio only for the session. For playback errors, check file location, access and format.